

EVERYDAY MILLIONAIRE

Phil grew up in Missouri. Both of his parents were teachers, so education was a priority in the family. He remembers his parents as being thrifty with their finances, and he admits they were great when it came to money management. In fact, Phil learned most of what he knows about money from his folks. Work was a big deal for the family, too. As a boy, Phil spent his days working on a dairy farm and picking cotton to earn money for himself. He wasn't scared of hard work, but those early days taught him he didn't want to spend the rest of his life out in the field. So he pursued a degree in chemical engineering and, like most of the millionaires in our research, he made it all the way through school with no student loans. Phil had plans for his life, and those plans didn't include years of student loan debt payments. Looking back, Phil said, "There is no way I would have borrowed money to go to school." He made it work with what he had, graduated with a great education, and took a job as an engineer right out of college.

Phil liked his company and he enjoyed his job, but he pushed himself to do more. After eight years in his engineering position, the company moved him into management, where he continued to grow and prosper for the next twenty years. When he saw more opportunities in the company's IT area, he transitioned to that field and spent the last twelve years of his career there. Every step of the way, Phil was invested in learning, growing, and sharpening his existing skills as well as learning entirely new skills. He was focused on making the biggest impact in his career, taking care of his family, and achieving financial independence. In all, Phil spent forty years—his entire career—at that one company.

Because he had invested so much into one company, Phil retired with a huge pension. Over the years, he also heavily invested in a 401(k) and an IRA. Now retired, and with a net worth of nearly \$4 million, he has a great perspective on what it took to hit the millionaire mark. The most important thing, he said, is to fund retirement accounts like the 401(k) and IRA—and to start early. Phil also said the budget was central to his finances all these years. And, of course, Phil said he stayed away from credit cards and other forms of debt throughout his entire life. He knew he'd never build wealth if he wasted his money on interest payments. "When you live for now and live with debt," he said, "you will never become a millionaire." It's also clear that his commitment to bettering himself in his career was crucial. He never stopped learning or growing, and he made an enormous investment in one company over forty years and six different cities. Now retired with millions in his accounts, he knows that investment paid off.
